Image Analysis: What You See 17



FIGURE 17.1 On the left is a carved medallion, found at Amaravati in a Buddhist shrine that dates from the later years BCE to the early CE. On the right, the individual images in the carving are outlined and numbered, explaining the narrative sequence and showing the audience how to "read" the medallion. Together, the two serve as an early example of visual rhetoric. (credit: "Chaddanta Jataja Amaravati" by Vidya Dehejia/Wikimedia Commons, CC0)

CHAPTER OUTLINE

17.1 "Reading" Images
17.2 Image Trailblazer: Sara Ludy
17.3 Glance at Genre: Relationship Between Image and Rhetoric
17.4 Annotated Student Sample: "Hints of the Homoerotic" by Leo Davis
17.5 Writing Process: Thinking Critically and Writing Persuasively About Images
17.6 Editing Focus: Descriptive Diction
17.7 Evaluation: Relationship Between Analysis and Image
17.8 Spotlight on ... Video and Film
17.9 Portfolio: Interplay Between Text and Image

INTRODUCTION Many people spend a substantial portion of their time watching and assessing images—including photographs, memes, graphs, and videos—via television, streaming services, and social media platforms. Even the college curriculum is as much visual as it is verbal, including as it does Internet research, computer graphics, and PowerPoint presentations. These forms of media might be relatively new, but people have been creating and consuming images for millennia, as you can see in Figure 17.1. An important part of human development consists of making images, enjoying them, and talking about them.

Formerly, visual texts were created exclusively by painters, photographers, and others generally designated as

artists. Today, given the proliferation of technologies that enable the easy capture and manipulation of images, such visual texts are created by a multitude of authors. In this chapter, terms for these image creators—artist, author, composer, creator—are used interchangeably.

Chapter 17 examines the elements of visual literacy and analysis most likely to complement the textual literacy emphasized in first-year writing classes and addressed in Print or Textual Analysis: What You Read. A critical understanding of visual texts is key to helping you both as a consumer of the frequent images you encounter in reading and viewing and as a producer who incorporates images into your own writing, as addressed in Multimodal and Online Writing: Creative Interaction between Text and Image. Overall, this chapter provides a solid basis for understanding visual rhetoric and communicating about it in various situations. After study and practice, you will be able to do so while drawing on your own cultural context, background, and experience and considering your audience, purpose, and rhetorical context.

17.1 "Reading" Images

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Define the key concepts and elements of visual rhetoric.
- Interpret visual information using the language of visual rhetoric.
- Interpret images differently based on cultural considerations.
- Choose digital and visual media according to the rhetorical situation and cultural context when writing for different audiences.
- Make informed decisions about intellectual property issues regarding images.

To compose an effective essay or a strong visual, a creator works with a number of elements that are remarkably similar from one medium to the other. Both stories and pictures contain **information** presented by a creator who has a particular point of view and arranges the work in two-dimensional space. The information is likely to be open to multiple **interpret**, which may or may not be justified by the text. Although the sharing of personal opinions and beliefs has value, the focus here is on interpreting or analyzing texts in combination with your personal experiences.

Interpreting Visual Information

Both words and pictures convey information, but each does so in different ways that require interpretation. *Interpretation* is the sense a person makes of a piece of communication—textual, oral, or visual. It includes personal experience, the context in which the communication is made, and other rhetorical elements. (See Glance at Genre: Relationship Between Image and Rhetoric for a list of key terms related to visual elements and rhetoric.) By the time readers get to college, they have internalized strategies to help them critically understand a variety of written texts.

Images present a different set of challenges for critical readers. For example, in a photograph or drawing, information is presented simultaneously, so viewers can start or stop anywhere they like. Because visual information is presented in this way, its general meaning may be apparent at a glance, while more nuanced or complicated meanings may take longer to figure out and likely will vary from one viewer to another.



FIGURE 17.2 Naked Raygun performance, 2007 (credit: “Naked Raygun” by Greg Dunlap/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

Some images, however, do not really lend themselves to interpretation. Before trying to engage in rhetorical discourse about an image, be sure it contributes something of value. For example, Figure 17.2 shows a punk rock concert featuring the band Naked Raygun with several concertgoers in the foreground. Such pictures are common forms of memorabilia that serve an archival function. The features common to visual rhetoric—point of view, arrangement, color, and symbol—do not inspire much in the way of discussion in this particular image. Parts are blurry, some of the figures are obscure, and the picture’s purpose is unclear. Therefore, any analysis of the image may be guided more by personal opinion than by critical thinking. Such images are *not* the focus of this chapter.



FIGURE 17.3 (credit: “DSCF1343” by K. Kendall, Portland, OR, USA/Wikimedia Commons, CC BY 2.0)

Figure 17.3, in contrast, depicts not merely a moment in time for the sake of memory, although it certainly does that. It contains a central, dominant figure. The color red is bold and centers the figure, giving the image

weight. It also conveys several political messages, both obvious and nuanced. The woman in the picture is wearing a mask, as people were either asked or mandated to do during the COVID-19 pandemic. The slogan on her mask reads "I can't breathe," words that were made infamous after Eric Garner (1970–2014) died as the result of an illegal chokehold inflicted by a New York City police officer during arrest. These words were repeated by George Floyd (1973–2020) in an 8-minute, 46-second video showing his murder by a Minnesota police officer who knelt on Floyd's neck. The phrase became one of several slogans of the Black Lives Matter (BLM) movement, symbolizing the struggle that people of color endure when living in an implicitly and explicitly racist culture. Breathing—like blood—is fundamental, essential. Without breath, there is no life. Thus, this slogan draws attention to the fact that people of color may be brutalized for no reason other than their existence.

Placing the slogan on a mask is a design choice likely to provoke those who have argued against mandated mask wearing as an assault on personal liberty and who have proclaimed they could not breathe while wearing masks. **Juxtaposition**, or placing contrasting elements close together, is a technique that image creators often use for a variety of purposes: humor, irony, sarcasm, or—as in this case—disgust or outrage. The juxtaposition of the mask with a slogan referencing literal asphyxiation emphasizes the wearer's view that state violence against people of color is a more serious threat to her existence than a mask. Thus, the image is open to multiple interpretations.

Thinking Critically

To think critically about visual information, first identify the objects, facts, processes, or symbols portrayed in the image. Taking all the information together, ask whether there is a main or unifying idea. *Is the meaning open to multiple interpretations? Is it suggested but not stated? Is it clear and unambiguous? Are there multiple levels of meaning, both stated and unstated?* When you view an image, pausing to answer such questions will sharpen your critical faculties, increase your understanding of the visual information you encounter, and help you use images more meaningfully in texts you create.

Visual Rhetoric

Written texts rely on strategies such as thesis statements, topic sentences, paragraphing, tone, and sentence structure to communicate their message to their audience. Images rely on different strategies, including **point of view**, **arrangement**, **color**, and **symbol**. When writing about images or including them in your writing, think critically about the visual strategies they use and the effect they will have on your audience.

Using these techniques may or may not make you a proficient artist or creator of images. However, familiarity with the technical language of the visual arts will certainly enable you to describe what you observe as you build the evidence that allows you to **interpret** an image, **reflect** on it, **analyze** it, and make **persuasive arguments** about it.

Point of View

In written texts, *point of view* refers to the "person" from whose vantage point the information is delivered, either a character in the story or a narrator outside the story. However, in photographs, drawings, and paintings, *point of view* refers to the place from which the image creator looks at the subject—where the photographer places their camera or the artist their easel.

Photographs that haven't been manipulated in a darkroom or digitally by a computer only reproduce the subject in front of the camera, as it exists in the moment the shutter opens and closes. They do not show anything to the left or right, above or below, or what comes before or after. A camera aimed to the east omits information from the north, west, and south. In other words, any photograph is the result of placing a camera in a certain location, at a certain height and distance, at a specific time of day and using a particular lens, film, and perhaps a filter. All of these decisions about where, when, and how to place the camera create the visual point of view.

You can find good examples of these kinds of limited truths in real-estate advertisements featuring photographs of houses for sale. The photograph might not reveal a landfill next door or a factory across the street—though you might infer such limitations from a low selling price or confirm them by driving past the house.



FIGURE 17.4 (credit: "Kodak Digital Waterfall" by Nan Palmero/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

The creator of Figure 17.4 chooses to highlight the digital waterfall with its seductive lighting and colors. Meanwhile, the people interacting with the computer are barely visible, standing off to the side, some nearly out of the frame. The silhouetted profiles and darkened faces lack identifying details. These features are emphasized by the blurred people in the background. These figures, too, are unidentifiable and are looking out of the frame, uninterested. The effect is to imply that the waterfall and its computer interface dominate human interaction and possibly even human existence.

To think critically about point of view, answer the following questions:

- From what place or stance does the image creator view the subject?
- What effect does this particular point of view have on the way viewers may think or feel about the subject?
- What would happen if the vantage point were elsewhere—above or below, left or right?
- What would change in the image if the point of view were changed?

Arrangement

In addition to point of view, artists use arrangement to signal an image's significance to the reader. The term *arrangement* in visual texts might be compared to terms such as *order*, *organization*, and *structure* in verbal texts, though the differences are substantial. While writers *arrange*, or put together, a story, essay, or poem to take place over time—that is, the time readers need to follow the text, line by line, through a number of pages—image creators arrange pictures in the two-dimensional space of their viewfinder, paper, or canvas to invite viewers to read in space rather than time. This difference is also evident in sculpture and other three-dimensional works, which require viewers to move around them to read them spatially. In visual texts, then, *arrangement* refers to the ways in which the various parts of a picture come together to present a single coherent experience for the viewer.

In contrast to static images, which are read spatially, videos and some types of **multimodal** texts—those incorporating more than one genre, discipline, or literacy (for example, GIFs that incorporate pictures or videos with language)—combine elements of both time and space. That is, they invite viewers to examine an image in motion that changes over time. Video creators often mimic linear time by telling a story, or they

repeat key images to be interpreted differently after being seen in various contexts within the video.

One element to examine is the use of **pattern**—predictable, repeated elements within the visual field that the eye notices and seems attracted to. Just as sonnets, sestinas, and haiku follow patterns of lines, so do visual compositions. But in these, patterns are created by light and color rather than words. Documentary and commercial photographers often use visual patterns to lead viewers to an intended meaning. Patterns are especially prominent in street art, where the elements of surrounding architecture and infrastructure interact with the work, as shown in Figure 17.5.



FIGURE 17.5 Gaza Strip mural in Prague, Czech Republic, by Blu (credit: "Gaza Strip" by Tom Hughes-Croucher/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

Many patterns are suggested by mathematics. For example, the **Möbius strip** is both a mathematical construct and a visual enigma. It has one side and one boundary curve. It looks like a spiral, but it does not intersect itself. Thus, it gives the impression of being infinite. In Figure 17.5, the artist capitalizes on these features of the Möbius strip, using it to depict the seemingly endless cycle of destruction (green tanks) and reconstruction (yellow steamrollers) in one of the world's most contested pieces of real estate: the Gaza Strip.

Ownership and control of the Gaza Strip are disputed. Approximately two million people live there, many in refugee camps. Since the mid-20th century, the region has been fought over by Israel, Egypt, and Palestinian Arabs. As you contemplate the mural, think about the way its creator uses pattern and repetition to convey various ideas and emotions. The following questions may help:

- Which elements within the mural are repeated?
- Where is its center of gravity or weight?
- Where do patterns of light/dark, large/small, and color lead the eye?
- How do pattern and balance contribute to meaning in a two-dimensional image?
- What does the arrangement suggest about the meaning of the image?

Color and Symbol

Pattern and arrangement are controlled by the image creator and intended to guide the viewer. Color and symbol allow the viewer greater latitude in interpreting the image, in part because particular colors suggest specific moods. Think about your personal reactions to different colors. *What color might you select to paint your bedroom? What is your favorite color for, say, clothing or cars?* While these may differ according to personal preference, traditional symbolic values are attached to different colors in literature and art. *Why, for instance, does red often symbolize anger or war on the one hand and romance or passion on the other? Why does black often suggest danger or death? And why does white often stand for innocence or purity? Are the*

reasons for these associations arbitrary, cultural, or logical?

Particular colors also suggest or reinforce social and political ideas. *What, for example, is suggested by adding a red, white, and blue American flag to a magazine advertisement for an American automobile, political poster, or bumper sticker? What is the meaning of a yellow ribbon tied to a tree in front of a house or an image of a yellow ribbon sticker attached to the tailgate of a pickup truck?* By themselves, colors do not specify political positions, arguments, or ideas, but used in conjunction with specific words or forms—a flag or ribbon, for example—the emotional power of color can be influential.

Color associations globally are complicated and highly nuanced. The following overview is brief and simplified, to be considered merely as an introduction or starting point for your research and investigations into individual artistic expressions. When you interpret an artist's use of color, one place to start is with the hues found in the natural world. Because blood is red, the color is often associated with life, heat, and passion. Yellow and green appear with the new growth of spring, so these colors often symbolize new beginnings, freshness, and hope. Both the sea and the sky are blue. Although these elements can be turbulent, many people find peace and tranquility as they reflect on them, and thus they are often associated with these emotions.



Regardless of colors' natural associations, people from around the world understand colors differently. In China, for example, red is a celebratory color associated with holidays, feasts, and the giving of gifts, whereas in some parts of Africa the color may symbolize the sacrifice necessitated by the fight for independence. In the Western world, white can represent purity or innocence and is often worn by young women at their weddings. However, in parts of Asia, white is a color of mourning.

The colors mentioned so far are mostly primary colors: red, yellow, and blue. The secondary colors—orange, green, and purple—carry more complex meanings. Both orange and the bright shade of green called neon or chartreuse are easy to see in all light conditions. Therefore, they are often used for safety purposes, on caution signs or uniforms of emergency workers. The color orange is associated with the robes of Buddhist monks, thus representing in Buddhist cultures that which is holy, whereas in the Netherlands, orange is the color of the royal family and used for patriotic purposes.

In addition to connotations of spring, the color green is also associated with Islam. In the Christian tradition, yellow and gold are colors associated with riches and abundance. Holiness is also associated with the color blue in Egyptian, Hindu, and Christian cultures (in which blue has other associations as well). Because purple has traditionally been a difficult color to manufacture, its rarity meant that only the very wealthy, often nobility or royalty, could afford to wear it—hence its association with royals and even gods. However, some cultures, such as Thai, Brazilian, and Italian cultures, associate purple with bad luck or death. Again, this overview of colors' different interpretations and associations is not intended as a guide for interpreting color in a visual image. Instead, consider all of the different ways in which color can be understood, some ways that the artist might intend for color to be interpreted, and the associations that colors have for you when you view a visual or digital image.



In this chapter, you have begun learning about how to interpret visual information through the lens of rhetoric. Color and its related symbolism help viewers interpret images.

Access multimedia content (http://openstax.org/books/writing-guide/pages/17-1-reading-images)

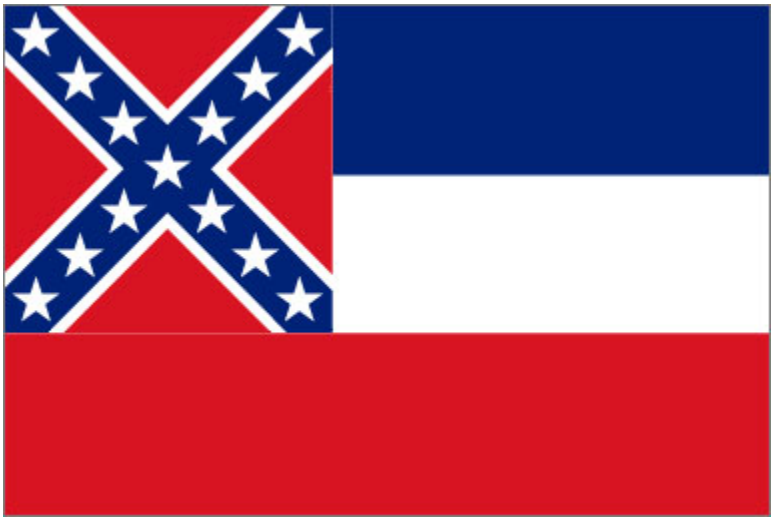


FIGURE 17.6 State flag of Mississippi (https://openstax.org/r/State-flag), 1894–2020. This is the 1894 version, without the white stripe added in 1996. (credit: "Flag of Mississippi (1894–1906)" by Wikimedia Commons/Public Domain)



FIGURE 17.7 The current state flag of Mississippi was adopted 2021. (credit: "Flag of Mississippi" by Rocky Vaughan, et al./Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

Symbols

Like colors, symbols are interpreted differently by individuals on the basis of their personal and cultural experiences. Here is an example of two state flags with very different symbolism: Figure 17.6 depicts the state flag of Mississippi that was adopted in 1894; Figure 17.7 depicts the one adopted in 2021. In 2021, under pressure from numerous organizations and in the wake of the Black Lives Matter movement, Mississippi replaced its state flag. The 1894 flag included the battle flag of the Confederacy, referencing Mississippi's history of secession and violence during the Civil War (1861–1865); the single blue, white, and red bands were a reference to the stripes on the American flag. This historical allusion, coupled with the state's history of enslavement and segregation, meant that the 1894 flag served as a stark reminder of efforts to silence Black Mississippians. In fact, Mississippi did not formally ratify the Thirteenth Amendment to the Constitution—proposed in 1865 to abolish slavery—until 2013, and the state remained segregated long after the Supreme Court outlawed the practice.

Mississippi continued to use the 1894 flag throughout the Reconstruction (1865–1877) and the Jim Crow laws (ca. 1877–c. 1950) and civil rights (1950s and 1960s) eras despite multiple and sustained efforts to remove any reference to the Confederate flag. In 2020, the increasing prominence of the Black Lives Matter movement

created the context in which state lawmakers were forced to consider these problems as mainstream and urgent. Further, the state came under pressure from numerous organizations, including the Southeastern Conference athletics organization (SEC), which threatened to boycott the state by no longer holding major events there if the flag were not changed.

Submitted to the legislature by Starkville-based graphic designer Rocky Vaughan (b. ca. 1977) and collaborators Sue Anna Joe, Kara Giles, and Dominique Pugh, the new flag took effect in January 2021 after voters approved it and the governor ratified it. The current flag (Figure 17.7) features a central vertical band of blue, flanked by two thin gold bands and encompassed by two broader red ones. The flag's center is dominated by a single magnolia flower, crowned by a single gold star and encircled by 20 white ones. Beneath the flower are emblazoned the words "In God We Trust."

The gold coloring is intended to celebrate Mississippi's contributions to the world of art, music, and literature. The white stars symbolize Mississippi's status as the 20th state of the Union; thus, the new flag symbolizes the state's reintegration into the Union without reference to its seditious acts in the 19th century or lingering loyalty to the beliefs that motivated them. In addition, the single gold star honors the state's indigenous people; no reference is made to the state's history of enslavement and racism.

Thinking critically about color and symbol, ask yourself these questions:

- Does the color enhance or distort the reality of the image?
- Imagine the image in shades of black, white, and gray. What would be lost and what would be gained if color were subtracted?
- Does the color work with or against the other compositional elements?
- What symbols are incorporated into the image? How might those symbols be interpreted in various contexts?
- What, if any, is the significance of referencing Indigenous but not Black Americans on the current flag?

Selecting and Incorporating Digital and Visual Media

In addition to analyzing visual and digital media, you may be asked to find, create, or manipulate such materials for a variety of situations and audiences. Following are some considerations to keep in mind, including **copyright** issues, appropriate selections, and **technical manipulations**.

Intellectual property laws are complicated, change frequently, and vary by country. Sharing an image is similar to quoting a text, with one exception: you must not only cite the author in a reference list or bibliography but also secure permission to use the image. To be safe, unless an image explicitly states that you are free to share it (public domain), assume it is protected by copyright.

The texts you write will have varying degrees of formality and require different levels of diction (word choice), syntax (sentence structure), content, and tone. Similarly, the images you select should reflect the **tone**, or attitude, that you wish to convey in your text. Ask yourself these questions to decide whether an image is appropriate for your text:

What is the image's purpose? Include images only if they add to or supplement the text. Do not add images simply as "filler" or for audience entertainment. Such materials are more likely to confuse or distract readers than they are to enlighten or inform them.

Is the image humorous or sarcastic? Humor has value as entertainment by keeping the audience interested and engaged in your text and making it more memorable. However, determining what makes something funny is deeply personal. An image you find funny could be read with confusion or even offense by someone else. In formal communications, humor and sarcasm are better avoided because of the risk of misunderstanding. In creative contexts, you have greater latitude.

Does the image include text? Because you are already creating a text, you may wish to question the value of

inserting an image with text. Consider what information the image provides in addition to the text. For example, in Figure 17.3, the text "I can't breathe" is enhanced by its placement on a mask and, further, by the mask's presence on a Black woman. These details make the image with its text a valuable addition to a discussion or analysis.

Consider also the language of the text. You may be fluent in multiple languages, so an image with text in Spanish, French, or Japanese could have meaning for you. *Will it have meaning for your audience?* The same applies to images that include slang, jargon, or slogans with a limited shelf life. If you have to explain the image's meaning before your readers understand it, the image is probably not worth including.

What is the image's context? Where and when the image is placed can affect the viewer's understanding and interpretation. A picture of poverty in one country is likely to look very different from poverty in another country. Some images can be considered universal, meaning they depict situations that have significance for all people, regardless of culture, ethnicity, or historical context. For example, an image of a mother and an infant is easily recognized by anyone anywhere and is likely to evoke similar thoughts and emotions.

What digital or technical requirements or manipulations are needed? Finally, when you think about including an image, you'll need to consider the digital and technical requirements and manipulations necessary to do so. Aspects to consider include compatibility requirements, visibility on different devices and platforms, sizing, and placement. The technical details associated with these considerations are changing rapidly, so this chapter makes no recommendations regarding software programs or specifications. However, if an image is blurred or distorted—or invisible—the result will be confusion and frustration on the part of your reader.

Selecting an Appropriate Image

To practice selecting appropriate images, imagine you are writing an informational webpage about the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) and its responsibilities in relation to the Clean Water Act. *To illustrate those responsibilities, which of the following images would you use? Why?* (Suggested answers follow.)

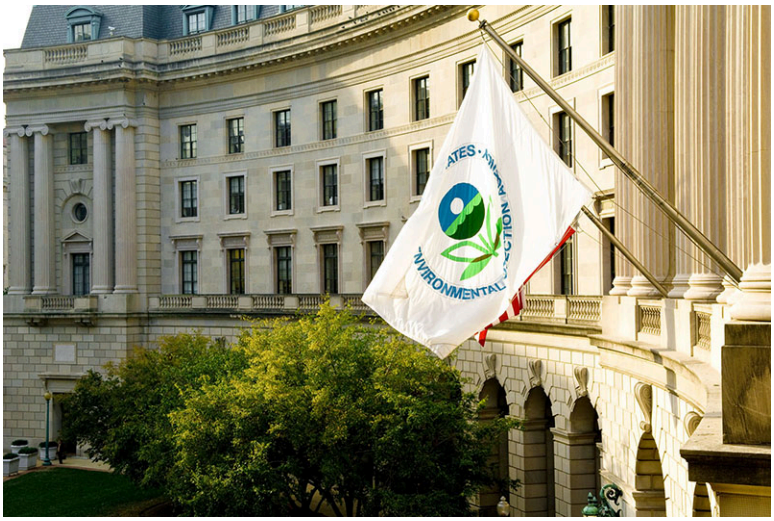


FIGURE 17.8 Sample image 1: EPA flag with logo (credit: "Environmental Protection Agency building" by USEPA Environmental-Protection-Agency/flickr, Public Domain



FIGURE 17.9 Sample image 2: Water pouring from a faucet into a clear glass (credit: “Water pouring from a faucet into a clear glass cup” by USEPA Environmental-Protection-Agency/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)



FIGURE 17.10 Sample image 3: Woman holding a cup of brown liquid (credit: “Safe Drinking Water Act” by Erik Calonius/USEPA Environmental-Protection-Agency/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

Suggested Answers

- **Sample image 1** seems like an obvious choice. It depicts the name and logo of the agency you are writing about, and nothing about it is likely to be considered controversial. However, by itself, it does not convey any useful information, so its purpose is unclear.
- **Sample image 2** depicts safe, clean drinking water from the tap. The glass emphasizes the clarity of the water, and its proximity to the tap shows the intimate role that water plays in daily life. It features no characters or setting, so it is not restricted by any obvious contextual clues. It is perfect for this piece.
- **Sample image 3** is emotionally powerful. It depicts a woman, older and likely with a low income, holding a

jar of brownish liquid. The image appears to be old, based on the coloring of the photograph, the woman's dress, and the home in the background. Its age could help make the rhetorical point that the EPA's enforcement of the Clean Water Act, passed in 1972, has been effective. However, its context is unclear, raising questions about its composition. *When and where was the photo taken? Is it set in the United States? And what is the liquid in the jar—water? Oil? Moonshine?* The image raises too many questions to be useful in this context.



17.2 Trailblazer

Image Trailblazer: Sara Ludy

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Interpret images through the conceptual lens of hybridity to learn, think critically, and communicate in a variety of rhetorical and cultural contexts.
- Articulate how genre conventions are shaped by purpose, culture, and expectation.



FIGURE 17.11 Images from nature inspire artists such as Sara Ludy (https://openstax.org/r/Sara-Ludy). (credit: "Plants OB 934" by USDA NRCS Montana/ Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

"The digital sublime emerges from a collectively built hyperobject that globally connects our nervous systems."

Sara Ludy and Hybridity





This chapter focuses on images. Still, most of the images with which viewers interact have been either created or manipulated digitally (https://openstax.org/r/digitally) and contain textual, animated (https://openstax.org/r/animated), and cinematic content. In the field of digital manipulation, Sara Ludy (https://openstax.org/r/Sara--Ludy) is a pioneer, combining painting, sculpture, floral arrangements, animation, sound, and video. She was raised in Bluemont, Virginia, a small town in the Appalachian region. She studied at the School of the Art Institute of Chicago (SAIC) and lived and worked in New Mexico and California before settling in Chicago. Her

work includes images of water, clouds, water vapor, birds, fabric, glass, and plants. American painter Georgia O'Keeffe's (1887–1986) influence—see Figure 17.12—on Ludy's work is obvious in its lush, open petals and wings, as well as in the vibrant natural colors.



FIGURE 17.12 *Red Canna*, 1919, by Georgia O'Keeffe (credit: "Georgia O'Keeffe Red Canna 1919" by Georgia O'Keeffe/High Museum of Art, Atlanta/Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

But Ludy also names British primatologist Jane Goodall (b. 1934); Argentine writer Jorge Luis Borges (1899–1986); and American architect, inventor, designer R. Buckminster Fuller (1895–1983) among her inspirations, emphasizing the hybrid nature of her work.

The concept of hybridity pervades Ludy's work, which occurs in different media and includes a variety of topics. The concept refers to mixing and is used in disciplines that encompass discussions of language, race, ethnicity, and culture. Relating to digital and visual media, the term *hybridity* incorporates pieces from each of these disciplines as well as the blending of practical, physical, technological, and artistic methods. The result is a piece of art that represents and speaks to people from multiple walks of life in various visual and tactile ways.

In particular, the concept of hybridity in the arts refers to the relationship between digital media and the creation and experience of the artwork. Artists such as Ludy anticipate that mixture by embedding it in their work, using digital techniques to distort or change it.

The following example of Ludy's work sheds light on her contributions to contemporary art and the multiple directions in which visual and digital media are headed in the 21st century.

Second Life: Convergence of the Virtual and the Physical

Ludy (https://openstax.org/r/Ludy) works extensively in the genre of *Second Life*, capturing and then manipulating images people have created. *Second Life* cannot be described merely as a video game, given the seriousness with which many people treat it and the lack of an ultimate goal or winning moment, but it does share features commonly found in video games. It is an animated alternative world where people spend long periods of time entertaining themselves. It represents a virtual reality in which participants design settings,

create characters, and engage in a variety of interactions. The goal is simply to be present in this virtual world, to create beautiful or intriguing spaces, and to experiment with form and color in ways that may not be possible in the real world. Ludy's *Second Life* work removes viewers even farther from the virtual experience's all-encompassing reality and heightens its surrealism using multiple layers of distance.

In interviews, Ludy encourages viewers to resist the urge to experience her work "consciously"—that is, to name or describe it. Instead, she wants them to focus on the sensory experiences they have when contemplating it. However, this advice is contrary to the goal of discourse, in which you describe and assess a work and your reactions to it. It also contradicts her own practice, in which she has commented on the nature of her practice and her intentions. Notice how, in the video, she talks about finding images in *Second Life* that resonate with a sense of familiarity. While many users may see *Second Life* as a place to invent new or unusual designs not permitted by physics, Ludy appears to be after those designs that make people feel at home, at least to the extent they can do so in a world constructed of binary code.

Elsewhere, Ludy describes the sublime as the happenstance that occurs when her virtual-reality-created scenes match a real-life experience she later has, much like witnessing an awe-inspiring natural phenomenon that appears supernatural and then realizing its natural qualities. Ludy instructs her viewers to "assume a prismatic quality" to her work (Ludy, "Artist"). Therefore, viewers should look at her images more than once, from different angles and perspectives and with different assumptions. In the case of the discovered floral arrangement she discusses, she refers to the pixelation—the radiation—the unintended effects of the digital relationship with the light and the camera.

Discussion Questions

1. Do you consider Ludy's photographs of design elements created in *Second Life* to be her own work or the work of another person? Explain your response.
2. In what ways is Ludy's *Second Life* photography practice "natural"? In what ways is it digital, artificial, or manipulated? How do those descriptions or designations affect the way you see, reflect on, or feel about her work?
3. Ludy refers to the "artifacts" she finds in her photographic images, such as the radiant light from the top of the floral arrangement creating a pseudo-star. Do you consider such "artifacts" of artistic interest, or do you believe they are flaws that represent byproducts of one's digital limitations? Explain your response.
4. In what ways is the experience of viewing, reflecting on, and discoursing about images similar to the *Second Life* experience? In what ways is it different?

17.3 Glance at Genre: Relationship Between Image and Rhetoric

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Analyze and reflect on images using the language of visual rhetoric.
- Articulate how genre conventions are shaped by purpose, culture, and expectation.
- Determine variations in genre conventions.

This section examines two sets of genre conventions: those associated with *visual rhetoric* and those associated with *writing about visual rhetoric*. The former include arrangement, color and symbol, composition, juxtaposition, light, line, multimodality, and point of view. These were introduced in 'Reading' Images and are summarized and defined at the end of this section. The latter conventions—reflecting, analyzing, and writing persuasively—are defined here with examples and suggestions for engaging in these kinds of writing. They serve as three frameworks for communicating the variety of human responses to images—responses that can range from apathy to repulsion, from enjoyment to bliss—using the language of visual rhetoric.

Reflecting and analyzing are addressed below. Writing persuasively is addressed in Writing Process: Thinking Critically and Writing Persuasively about Images in connection with this chapter's writing assignment. However, remember that all writing about images relies first on description and is persuasive in that its purpose is to convince readers to consider the ideas presented.

Reflecting on Images

When you **reflect** on an image, you process its technical elements through the dual lens of critical thought and personal experience. You may ask questions such as the following:

- Does this image resonate with me? Why or why not?
- How does this image make me feel?
- What memories or associations does this image summon for me?
- How might my thoughts, feelings, and associations evoked by the image differ from those of someone else—someone of a different gender, socioeconomic context, or culture?

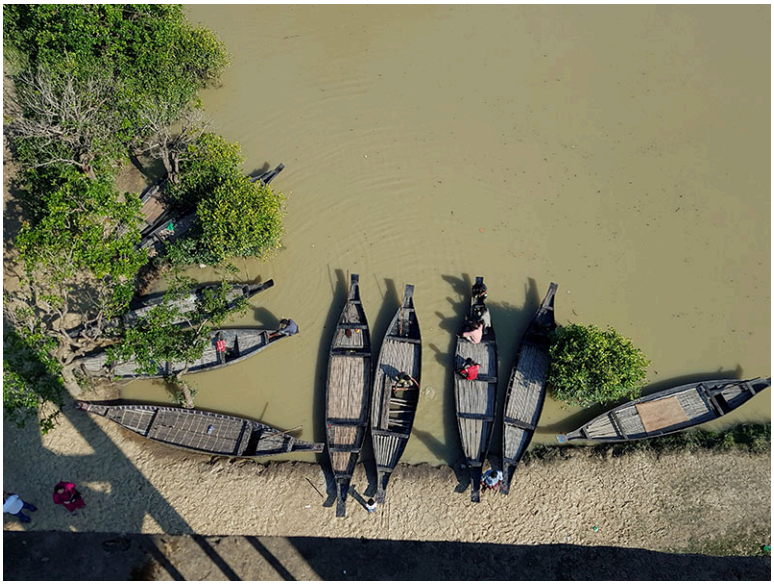


FIGURE 17.13 Boats carrying tourists in Ratargul Swamp Forest, Bangladesh (credit: "Ratargul swampland, Sylhet" by Mostaque Chowdhury/flickr, CC BY 2.0)

To respond to some of these questions, consider Figure 17.13. Images of nature are often used to either soothe the viewer or inspire a sense of grandeur. Figure 17.13 has the capacity to do both. The repeating horizontal and vertical lines, gradient color patterns, and whimsical spots of pink and red directly offer a visual appeal that encourages meditation and reflection. A bare understanding of the context similarly lends a sensation of awe to the image. Ratargul is both a forest and a swamp in a remote part of Bangladesh that floods regularly. Tourists frequent the location, and local residents capitalize on that fact by giving them guided boat tours along the river, despite the inherent dangers.

But this image can be further informed by a viewer's variety of personal experiences. Consider, for example, the extent to which you have traveled. *Is Bangladesh within the realm of possibility for you—in the past, now, or ever? What are your experiences as a tourist or in the service industry? Do you think the boat operators and the photographer have similar or different opinions of the scene?* When you think and write critically about such questions, you deepen your understanding of your own experiences and reactions, you interact with the experiences of others, and you understand the world more broadly and deeply.

Remember that reflecting necessarily contains an element of speculation. Be careful to ground your discussion

in evidence—from the image itself, from the image's context, or from your own experience. Beyond these, such discussions devolve into self-indulgent musings that few others can share in or learn from.

Analyzing Images

When describing an image, you might state that a line is blue. When you **analyze** an image, you might discuss what the color and the line *mean* or *do*. The images in 'Reading' Images are analyzed according to genre elements specific to visual media. In these discussions, the analysis begins with description, but it does not end there. The elements of visual rhetoric are both described and analyzed to discover the artist's intentions. (You will read a detailed analysis about painter Charles Demuth's *Dancing Sailors* in the Annotated Student Sample.)

When you analyze an image, you contribute to an ongoing global discussion, helping create the kaleidoscope that makes such rhetorical discussions meaningful. Do not worry about whether your contribution is right or wrong. Instead, consider its value to the global discussion. *What can you say that would broaden understanding of the work of art and your experience of the world?* This task may seem overwhelming, especially when you consider the work of a well-known artist. But your experiences and opinions are unique and valuable.

So far, this task sounds a lot like reflection, with one difference: reflection focuses on personal responses, reactions, feelings, and experiences, whereas analysis broadens that discussion to include the effects of various technical elements on a variety of people in different contexts. When analyzing an image, consider some of the following questions:

- Why did the creator select these particular technical elements?
- How are various audiences likely to react to them?
- How have interpretations of the image changed over time, or how are they likely to change in the future?
- What effect does historical or current context have on your interpretation?

The Language of Visual Rhetoric

Images speak to viewers in a language that short-circuits their critical thought processes and goes directly to their sensory receptors. Yet unlike a simple, instinctive response to stimuli, the goal of critical thought, reflection, and discourse is to consider *how* and *why* viewers respond the way they do to certain images. To do so, viewers should consider the techniques that artists use to elicit such reactions. In this way, artists and viewers create a shared language of visual rhetoric in which both can discuss the virtues and demerits of a work of art as well as its historical and artistic contributions.

Key Terms in Visual Rhetoric

- **Arrangement:** Artists arrange their work to emphasize certain aspects and to create patterns of repetition and variation. The term *composition* is often used to mean *arrangement*.
- **Color and symbol:** Images communicate their meaning in part through the variety and interplay among colors. Even the choice to use black and white or a monochrome color palette is a color choice. Symbols in images allude to deeper meanings.
- **Composition:** Composition is often used as an umbrella term encompassing all aspects of visual rhetoric. It can also be used synonymously with *arrangement* to indicate how the piece is put together.
- **Juxtaposition:** In visual art, juxtaposition is the placement of contrasting images close together to emphasize their connection, lack of connection, or incongruity.
- **Light:** Unique to images is the use of light to highlight or obscure various parts of an image or to create prismatic effects that enhance its repetitive aspects.
- **Line:** In addition to outline shapes, artists use line to focus or center the viewer's eye and then to move it across the image in certain predetermined patterns.
- **multimodal:** Multimodality is the use of more than one type of literacy within a single work. For example,

an airline display board is a multimodal work because it requires viewers both to understand ways of reading airport codes, time zones, and visual representations of temporal data and to relate that information to the their current circumstances. Multimodality is a theory, perspective, or method that incorporates the consideration of all elements of an image.

- **Point of view:** Also called **perspective**, point of view encompasses what an image includes, what it excludes, and where its focus lies.

17.4 Annotated Student Sample: "Hints of the Homoerotic" by Leo Davis

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Determine the context of an image.
- Analyze the rhetorical techniques common to images.
- Analyze a variety of texts according to organizational patterns and rhetorical techniques.

Introduction

Below you will find a student analysis of a painting by Charles Demuth. As you read it, pay careful attention to the way in which the student author, Leo Davis, describes technical details of the painting, such as color, line, and technique. Also notice the way he analyzes those details, moving beyond mere description into the realms of context, analysis, and reflection.

Meet American Modernist and Precisionist Charles Demuth (1883–1935)



FIGURE 17.14 *Self-Portrait*, 1907 (credit: "Self portrait of Charles Demuth" by Charles Demuth/Wikimedia Commons, CC0)

Charles Demuth was an American painter of the modernist and precisionist movements. Trained at the Pennsylvania Academy of Fine Arts, he traveled to Europe and worked as an illustrator before striking out on his own, first as a watercolorist and then as an oil painter. His watercolors follow languid lines of vegetation, reproducing plants and flowers in stronger geometric patterns than those of his friend and fellow artist

Georgia O'Keeffe (1887–1986). His work in the precisionist movement, like that of other similar artists, often focuses on industrial subjects enhanced by exaggerated geometric techniques. Few human characters appear in Demuth's paintings, which tend to erase any suggestion of his own personality or brushstroke on the artwork.

Demuth was a keen wit with a vibrant social presence in New York, Paris, and London. He cultivated his friendships as avidly as he did his art, and his company was much prized. His homosexuality was likely well known among his circle of friends, although his works depicting gay subculture in major metropolitan areas were only privately circulated. These works, including *Dancing Sailors* (https://openstax.org/r/Dancing-Sailors) seen in black and white in Figure 17.15, are today shedding light on the ways in which LGBTQ people engaged with one another and society more than 100 years ago.



FIGURE 17.15 *Dancing Sailors*, c. 1918, by Charles Demuth (credit: "Dancing sailors" by Charles Demuth/ Wikimedia Commons, Public Domain)

LIVING BY THEIR OWN WORDS

Analysis of *Dancing Sailors* by Charles Demuth

> Four male sailors dance on a checked floor with arched lines in the background. Two of the men dance with women, while two of them dance with each other. This painting is done in watercolor and graphite and focuses on the sailor on the far left. The other figures face him, and his posture draws the viewer's eye to his face. The man and woman on the far right seem completely involved with each other. The two couples in the middle are drawn sensually, with passion, but none of them focus on their own partners. Instead, the two sailors with their backs to the viewer stare at one another. The sailor on the left appears quite aggressive, with an arched back and bent knees suggesting a pelvic thrust. Although his dance partner is a woman, he holds her right hand at arm's length, away from his body, and stares past her toward the sailor next to him. Strong pencil strokes emphasize his eyes and eyebrows, pointing the viewer to the object of his stare. The central sailor is dancing with a man in a mutual embrace, but his attention is fixed on the sailor at left, his head tilted slightly and his expression receptive. The painting is signed and dated: "C Demuth - 1918 -."

Description. *The initial paragraph focuses extensively on the visual elements of the painting, with a few analytical passages. Leo Davis uses descriptive, artistic terminology such as "arched," "watercolor and graphite," and "[s]trong*

pencil strokes" to help readers visualize the painting.

Line and Arrangement. *Davis provides some details about the artistic techniques used, such as the strong pencil strokes and the way the image "emphasize[s] his eyes and eyebrows."*

Analysis. *The author explains the effect of these elements and techniques to interpret the poses and intentions of the characters in the painting.*

A Vibrant Subculture and a World in Crisis

> *Dancing Sailors* was painted by Charles Demuth (1883–1935), a key figure in early-20th-century modernism. Best known as a watercolorist, Demuth also painted the gay subculture in jazz clubs and underground bars in New York City in works that he kept secret. As a gay man, he frequently visited Manhattan during the Harlem Renaissance and participated in this culture, savoring the artistic and erotic intensity of the Jazz Age.

> Although the art movement in the early 20th century was vibrant, its context was depressing. The United States entered World War I (1914–1918) in April 1917. A month later, the Selective Service Act was passed, and thousands of American men were drafted into military service. In March 1918, the United States was hit with the influenza pandemic. Twenty million people died in the war, and another 50 million died from the flu.

> Meanwhile, in 1916, the U.S. military began using so-called blue discharges to force gay people out of the armed forces. By 1919, sailors were arrested and court-martialed for homosexual activity. It seems seriously unfair that someone who fought in the war could come back home and be convicted as a criminal just for his sexual orientation.

> In this context, with death seemingly everywhere and gay men hated, Demuth created striking watercolors that say a lot about his times. Because he did not share these paintings publicly, he was probably afraid of revealing his own homosexuality. But that did not stop him from making art that reflected his own desires. *Dancing Sailors*, now in possession of the Cleveland Museum of Art in Ohio, was not intended for public exhibition.

Context. *In these four well-organized paragraphs, Davis outlines the painting's context: key details about the artist's personal life, the military and domestic situations in America, and Demuth's place in this world. Davis focuses on the aspects most relevant to the artwork, keeping the context short and pointed.*

Tension within a Painting

> The perspective, or point of view, of the painting is high, as shown by the angle of the black-and-white checkerboard floor and where it hits the wall. The figures are shown in a practical close-up, so that their feet and the tops of their heads are not included in the frame. This perspective is very intimate, but with the audience intruding on the scene. All of the couples hold each other closely and tightly, and the audience is almost uncomfortably close.

Point of View. *Davis returns to technical description, indicating the artist's perspective and how it affects the viewer.*

> Demuth uses watercolor to outline the dancers' bodies, making the clothing almost transparent. The silhouette of the pants emphasizes the bulge of thigh and calf muscles, and the arches in the background suggest erections. For both men, the buttocks are outlined and emphasized. The male dancers are clearly wearing uniforms, but Demuth chooses not to include insignias, medals, or other identifying marks. Perhaps he was simply not interested in military rank and regulation. Or maybe he wanted to direct the viewer's attention elsewhere. The two women in the painting are incidental, their bodies largely obscured by the men. Although the figures are outlined in graphite, the textured watercolor unites the dancers with the background, making them seem very much like they belong in this scene of intimacy.

Artistic Medium and Line. *Davis discusses the medium—watercolor—and how Demuth's use of it creates the impression of tight clothing. Importantly, the author does not assume intent on Demuth's part, although he speculates. Instead, he limits his analysis to the details and artistic techniques of the painting.*

Technical Description. *Again, the author keeps this paragraph focused on an element of artistic design: the watercolor. He backs his assertion with evidence from the painting. Instead of simply saying that the men are wearing tight clothing, he describes the artist's use of watercolor to create the impression of tight clothing.*

> The painting appears to tell a story, but only in part. The viewer is invited to fill in the blanks. The sailors in the foreground are blatantly flirting with one another. And the central sailor's direct stare at the viewer may be considered an invitation. His wide-eyed expression, slight smile, and hands curled to embrace his dance partner's torso indicate pleasure. The viewer knows something this sailor does not: his part of this story is unlikely to have a happy ending. The female dance partners, while largely obscured, are still individuals with strong personalities. The woman on the left has a vacant stare from half-closed eyes, and her indifferent posture suggests that she may be bored, but the curve of her hip is still sexual. Is she offended by her partner's distraction?

Arrangement. *Davis invites viewers to "read" the painting, to see the story being told by the arrangement, which also invites them to notice the two women.*

Rhetorical Question. *This technique allows the student author to pose provocative questions that have no clear answers. In combination with the accompanying analysis, the rhetorical question helps establish the tone and theme of the painting that Leo Davis wishes to explore.*

Lasting Significance

> Demuth was a gay man during a difficult time in American history. This painting, one of many he kept private, is sympathetic and nonjudgmental. These private paintings may have been his attempt to find and show his acceptance of his own identity. During World War I, many military men came to port cities such as New York. Also during that time, Demuth enjoyed the Manhattan nightlife, and he painted a number of scenes of this changing environment. His personal involvement is interesting in and of itself. But even more so, these private paintings document the emergence of a sexual subculture and mark an important moment in American gay history.

Context and Analysis. *The author uses context and analysis to reach a conclusion about Demuth's intention in creating the painting and its significance in the history of American homoerotic art.*

> Although Demuth died at the relatively early age of 52, his work remains influential in American art. The geometric background of *Dancing Sailors* shows his increased interest in architectural watercolors. Later in his career, these paintings were hailed as key to the development of the precisionist movement. His unique expressions of modernism are a precursor to the abstract expressionism that developed in the 1940s and later influenced pop art innovators such as Andy Warhol (1928–1987). Aside from its historical significance, the vibrant sensuousness of *Dancing Sailors* continues to have relevance and appeal for art lovers today.

Context. *Leo Davis concludes by extending his argument for Demuth's influence, tracing the effect of his work through later artists and movements and stating the reason Dancing Sailors continues to have value as a work of art.*

Discussion Questions

1. In which of the three types of writing about art—reflecting, analyzing, persuading— is the student author engaging? How do you know?
2. Identify some of the descriptive language specific to visuals that Leo Davis uses when talking about the painting. How does this language enhance the paper and contribute to the discussion?
3. From the essay, can you determine Davis's opinion regarding homosexuality? Why might this tone be or not be a significant part of the rhetorical situation?
4. What details does the student author include about the painter? Is any information about the painter excluded that you think would be relevant?

17.5 Writing Process: Thinking Critically and Writing Persuasively About Images

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Develop a writing project through multiple drafts.
- Employ a variety of drafting strategies to complete an analysis of images.
- Apply aspects of visual rhetoric to a writing project.
- Participate in the collaborative and social aspects of writing processes.
- Give and act effectively on productive feedback.

In this section, you will combine what you learned earlier about reflecting on and analyzing images with another way of writing about images: writing persuasively, or persuading. Like reflecting and analyzing, writing persuasively requires clear, vivid descriptions of the technical aspects of an artwork, such as point of view, arrangement, color, and symbolism, as explained in Glance at Genre: Relationship Between Image and Rhetoric. Remember that reflecting on an image helps you make sense of both the image and your experience from different perspectives. Reading other people's reflections expands your universe of experience. Analyzing images improves your critical thinking skills by synthesizing description, reflection, and logical thinking to determine what an image's design elements mean. You write persuasively about images when you determine that an image's meaning has or does not have a value (that you define) for its viewers. For example, Leo Davis, in his analysis of *Dancing Sailors* in Annotated Student Sample, determines the homoerotic message in the image and the painter's tone or attitude toward his subject. You can also extend the scope of persuasion to make a recommendation about the status or merit of the work, as you will do in this assignment.

Writing Persuasively about Images

Like reflection, persuasion starts with context and description and can include personal reflections. The difference is primarily in the purpose and often the tone, or attitude toward the subject and audience. The purpose generally falls into one of three categories:

- ***What is the image's value?*** In the art world, these discussions are commonplace. Major publications such as the *New Yorker* or *Harper's Magazine* publish reviews of artists, galleries, and exhibitions. Critics and scholars argue that such discussions serve to establish a society's values and to benchmark the limits of what a society will and will not tolerate. Certainly, 2020 witnessed an explosion of such conversations. Protestors created images meant for display on public property, many of which were identified as graffiti or acts of vandalism; streets and other locations were renamed to reflect a growing awareness of the role that Black excellence has played in America's history; and monuments and memorials relating to injustice were reevaluated, vandalized, and removed.
- ***What happened?*** Forensic arguments often relate to legal situations, in which lawyers, judges, and juries try to determine what happened and how to respond. In the case of images, these techniques are applied to assess the circumstances of an image's creation as well as its critical and modern reception.
- ***What should happen?*** In the public sector, officials decide whether to fund artistic works. In the private sector, companies decide on images that faithfully represent their brands and values.

In persuasive writing, the purpose is usually revealed in a **thesis statement**, a single sentence, sometimes two, that defines the author's position and gives one or more reasons for it. The thesis usually appears at the end of the introduction, although it can occur at the start of either the introduction or the conclusion.

Look again at Figure 17.3, in which a woman wears a mask that reads, "I can't breathe." Table 17.1 below outlines a thesis statement based on that image that might apply to each of the three persuasive writing purposes.

Persuasion Purpose	Sample Thesis Statement
What is the image's value?	The image of the mask, its text, and the woman wearing it convey an important message that serves as a valuable artifact representing many of the complexities of 2020.
What happened?	The mask wearer is sending a valuable message that people need to hear in the context of the controversies surrounding both the pandemic and the racial situation in America in 2020.
What should happen?	The mask's message and context are inflammatory during a public health crisis; therefore, the use of masks with potentially political commentary should be discouraged in public places.

TABLE 17.1 Sample thesis statements by persuasion purpose

Tone

The tone of a persuasive piece can range from educational to impassioned and is largely based on the audience to which it is directed. Most writing about images is done in the neutral tone typically adopted in academic writing, although you may find reviews or essays that are informal and others that are scholarly.

Taking a Side

In 'Reading' Images, you read a description of and some reflections on Figure 17.3, an image of woman wearing a mask reading, "I Can't Breathe." You also read a brief analysis of the figure, combining description, historical context, and the visual design element of juxtaposition. Now, in Table 17.2, look at what two sides of a persuasive discussion of Figure 17.3 might look like.

Side A	Side B
Purpose / Thesis	
Figure 17.3 represents an important moment in American history and should be included in a yearbook recording historical events of 2020.	Figure 17.3 depicts an ordinary occurrence and does not warrant inclusion in a yearbook recording historical events of 2020.
Audience	
Committee commissioned by the National Endowment for the Humanities	
Context	
The committee has been commissioned to publish a yearbook of 2020, entitled *The Year Democracy Roared*. They are looking for pictures that represent large movements in America in 2020 that tie into the country's history and depict individuals in interesting or unique settings.	

TABLE 17.2 Elements of a persuasive argument about an image

Side A	Side B
Evidence	
• The image features a Black woman wearing a mask that reads, "I Can't Breathe." • The pandemic of 2020 caused many people to wear masks, either by choice or by mandate. • Some people did not support mask wearing because of their political beliefs regarding personal liberties. • During 2020, the Black Lives Matter movement gained widespread support. • "I Can't Breathe" was one of several slogans adopted by the Black Lives Matter movement. • The image juxtaposes the mask with the slogan in an ironic statement open to multiple interpretations.	• Many people wore masks in 2020 for reasons unassociated with politics or controversy. • Many people decorated their masks with a variety of images and slogans. • The choice of whether to wear a mask was, in many cases, not a choice but a mandate. • This woman is not in obvious distress or at a protest. • The image includes another woman, reflected in the first woman's sunglasses, not wearing a mask, calling into question the seriousness of her mask message. • The woman does not appear to be part of a larger movement, engaged in a unique or interesting activity, or placed in an unusual setting.

TABLE 17.2 Elements of a persuasive argument about an image

Summary of Assignment: Writing Persuasively about an Image

Public works projects such as stadiums or convention centers, private developments such as condominiums and shopping centers, and online spaces such as websites and social media platforms all commission artists to create exclusive works for display. These works are intended to reflect the vision of the artist as well as to promote the brand or mission of the space. Imagine that you have been asked to analyze an artist's work to determine whether the artist should contribute to the development of a local space that you select. Select the work of an artist, either Sara Ludy (https://openstax.org/r/Sara.Ludy) or another artist whose work is familiar to you or whose work you would like to learn more about. See Further Resources at the end of this chapter for suggested museums to visit in person or online. You can choose from historical figures or living artists. You can even choose an artist who illustrated a graphic novel you have read. Once you have chosen an artist and an image created by that artist, identify the aspects of the work you wish to assess, and support your analysis with technical descriptions of the image. Then, explain why you reached your decision about the artist's contribution to the selected space.

The parts in this section will take you through the development of a sample essay, using the example of American sculptor James Earle Fraser's (1876–1953) *Equestrian Statue of Theodore Roosevelt*. As you follow along in this process, consider how it applies to your topic. Think of the process as divided into these six steps:

1. Identify the rhetorical situation.
2. Outline the elements you intend to analyze.
3. Write an introduction in which you frame the image and the context in which you intend to discuss it.
4. As you draft, or before you draft the body of the essay, write topic sentences to identify the focus of each paragraph on a specific technical or contextual aspect of the image.
5. Build your paragraphs by describing the relevant elements.
6. Conclude by suggesting directions to consider in the future.

Another Lens 1. Visit Sara Ludy's website (https://openstax.org/r/Sara.Ludy) and select an image, a rendering, or an animation that speaks to you in some way, and identify the technical aspects you wish to assess. Support your analysis with descriptions of the image, using the vocabulary introduced in "Reading" Images and Glance

at Genre: Relationship Between Image and Rhetoric. Then, as an option, consider whether or not you would advise an individual to purchase the work or how you would advise an organization to use it (or not use it) as a representative image—for example, as part of a logo or cover for a publication.

Another Lens 2. Another option for assessing an artist's work is to compare and contrast this work with another piece, either by Sara Ludy or by a different artist. In doing so, you may consider ways in which the artist and their work have changed over time, or you may consider the influence one artist has on another. Finally, you may consider the images in different contexts through the lens of the artists' experiences, places in history, personal identities, and artistic practices.

Another Lens 3. Consider a work from a multimodal perspective. If you are interested in the connections of art and culture, consider choosing a piece of historic or contemporary Native American art. You can find information and view images at the websites for the National Museum of the American Indian (https://openstax.org/r/National) and the *Hearts of Our People: Native Women Artists* (https://openstax.org/r/Hearts-of-Our) exhibition at the Smithsonian American Art Museum. Create an **infographic** or a short video assessing the chosen artwork. An infographic incorporates multiple images and texts into a single image that can be read and understood quickly. A short video could work in a similar way, but the images would be presented sequentially with narration, either spoken or written. Your multimodal work should consider the elements of visual rhetoric discussed throughout this chapter and combine reflection with analysis and persuasion. See Multimodal and Online Writing: Creative Interaction between Text and Image for more information on creating a multimodal work.

Quick Launch: Identify Rhetorical Context



FIGURE 17.16 *Equestrian Statue of Theodore Roosevelt* , 1940, by James Earle Fraser, New York City (credit: "Theodore Roosevelt Memorial Hall entrance" by edwardhblake/Wikimedia Commons, CC BY 2.0)

In this writing example, the statue of former U.S. president Theodore Roosevelt (1858–1919) (Figure 17.16) is analyzed as part of the museum's decision to keep it or remove it. To begin, the author of this paper (a college student, U.S. citizen, and nursing major) defines the rhetorical situation: purpose, audience, genre, stance,

context, and culture. Complete the first step in the assignment as this author has done by consulting the writer's triangle to sketch out these elements. The writer's triangle (Figure 17.17) includes audience, genre, and stance and is surrounded by the circle of context/culture. The image allows you to "shorthand" your ideas about these elements during the brainstorming phase, as the author has done beneath the figure.

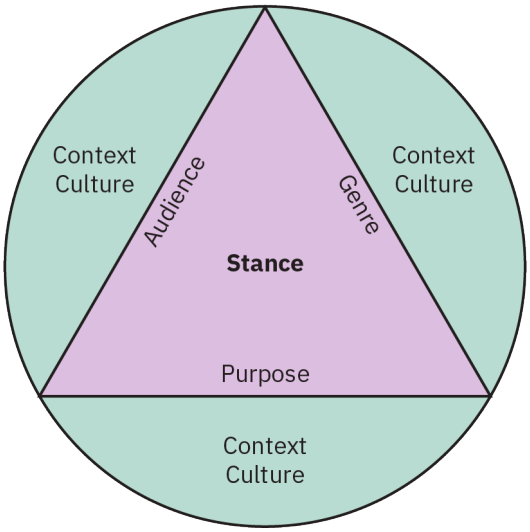


FIGURE 17.17 Writer's triangle (attribution: Copyright Rice University, OpenStax, under CC BY NC-SA 4.0 license)

- **Purpose:** To analyze the Equestrian Statue of Theodore Roosevelt
- **Audience:** Instructor, fellow students, and U.S. residents
- **Genre:** Print or digital newsletter or magazine article
- **Stance:** To support the American Museum of Natural History's decision to remove the statue of Theodore Roosevelt
- **Context:** Roosevelt's presidency and what he accomplished, the relationship between him and the American Museum of Natural History, and the elements of the statue warranting its inclusion or exclusion
- **Culture:** Critics have said that the statue depicts Black people and Native Americans as conquered and culturally substandard.

Note: Do not confuse context with your rhetorical situation, which, in this case, is a writing assignment for a college course, part of a portfolio and a learning technique in which you practice a type of civil discourse. Meanwhile, context in this case refers to the image—the circumstances of its creation, its technical elements, and how its meaning may change over time.

Sometimes the elements of your rhetorical situation are not made explicit. Signs that you need clarification include the following:

- Trouble getting started
- Difficulty understanding how much background information to provide
- Not knowing which terms are too technical or which need to be defined

For clarity about purpose, audience, genre, or culture, talk to your peers and instructor using the questions in Table 17.3 as a guide.

	Questions to Consider	Your Responses
Purpose	With regard to the image, are you writing to describe, to reflect, to analyze, or to evaluate (persuade)?	
Audience	Who is the audience? What do they already know about the image? What do they need to know? Toward what cultural issues might you need to show sensitivity?	
Genre	What are the characteristics of the genre in which you will compose your analysis of the image?	
Stance	What direction should your thesis statement take?	
Context	Within what social, political, economic, or cultural context was the image created, and for what purpose?	
Culture	What cultural issues are related to the image? From what cultural viewpoint are you writing? What is the cultural viewpoint of your audience?	

TABLE 17.3 Questions to determine the elements of your rhetorical situation

Regarding context, you may need to do some research on the image:

- Who is the image's author?
- When was it created?
- For what purpose was it created?
- Has the image been featured in reviews or the news?
- Does the image include important symbols or references?

After you have defined your rhetorical situation, write a working thesis for your paper. Consider using one or a combination of these frames. You may change the phrasing as needed to make your point.

- The artist's choice of _____ shapes the viewer's understanding of _____.
- The artist incorporates _____ to symbolize _____.
- The image's point of view reveals that _____.
- The artist's style, including _____, suggests that _____.
- The image evokes feelings of _____.

Drafting: The Visual to the Textual

After you have a working thesis, move on to the next major step: outlining the visual elements you intend to analyze. Review the material in "Reading" Images and Glance at Genre: Relationship Between Image and Rhetoric. In the case of the Roosevelt statue, the author has thought about which technical elements of the statue to analyze. The author also has considered the important aspects of the historical context shaping Theodore Roosevelt's life, presidency, and legacy; the museum and the cultural events in the year the statue was erected; and the cultural events in the year the decision is being made about whether to remove the statue. Remember that you may need to do some additional research to supplement your understanding of the context.

Analyze the Image

With a larger understanding of your subject's social, political, and cultural context, you can now begin to analyze the image. Limit your descriptions to what you can see and what your observations imply. Consider the following examples:

- **Pattern.** Identify the repetition of the figures, but note the differences in the ways each is depicted. Identify any lines or other elements that are repeated with variation.
- **Point of view.** The statue is tall and on a pedestal, requiring viewers to look up or see it from a distance.
- **Arrangement.** Three figures are arranged in a triangle, suggesting an apex with two supporting angles. Among the figures, the president is tallest, always visible, whereas the two accompanying figures can be seen fully only from either the front or the back. From the side, one or the other is always obscured.
- **Symbolism.** Each man is dressed in the clothing representative of his homeland. The two to the side are clearly allegorical, whereas the one on top is given individuality and freedom of expression.
- **Conclusion.** Outline criteria that could be used in the future to determine how symbols of or memorials to historical figures should be assessed.

Write an Introduction

In your introduction, name the artist, the image, and the context in which you intend to discuss it. See the suggestions above for research you may need to do regarding context. If you do research, remember to cite the sources you use because this information did not originate with you. The context may consist of one or two paragraphs, depending on how much information your audience needs to understand your analysis. (This is one reason to have a good understanding of your audience.) This type of introduction appears frequently in visual analyses and persuasive papers.

The two keys to writing a strong context are (1) being selective about what you include and (2) framing your own analysis. For example, Theodore Roosevelt is an important historical figure, and many books have been written about him. Even two paragraphs are insufficient to summarize every relevant detail about him. Likewise, the American Museum of Natural History plays a significant role in documenting mammalian life and has a vital, if at times controversial, role in American scientific history. In the two paragraphs below, the author selects details about the president, the museum, and the statue that both highlight the reasons they are admired and touch on their potential failings. These details are not all-inclusive; they are carefully culled from all of the available information to lead up to the subsequent analysis, which focuses on the reasons to remove the statue. The last sentence in the second paragraph is the thesis, in which the author states her agreement with the museum's decision.

Contextual Introduction

> Theodore Roosevelt cultivated a hearty outdoor lifestyle, exploring the Dakota Territory in the 1890s, serving as a Rough Rider during the Spanish-American War (1898), and advocating for the conservation of America's natural resources. Despite criticism for the way in which he acquired the land and rights to construct the Panama Canal, he was widely respected both at home and abroad, being awarded the Nobel Peace Prize (1906) for helping negotiate a peace treaty between Japan and Russia. After his presidency, he traveled extensively throughout Africa and South America, where he killed many animals and returned them to serve as specimens in America's natural history museums. He was himself shot while campaigning, but as the bullet did not penetrate his lung, he gave his speech regardless, earning him the reputation of a bull moose.

> A statue commemorating Roosevelt was presented to the public in 1940, two decades after his death, and placed in front of the American Museum of Natural History in New York City, where Roosevelt served as governor from 1899 to 1900. On one side of Roosevelt, depicted on horseback at the center of the sculpture, walks an African person, and on the other an Indigenous person. All three figures have a straight, proud posture and look directly ahead of them, toward the future. Given its placement, the statue is likely intended as an allegory, depicting the men of two continents—Africa and North America, including its Indigenous people—on a voyage of discovery and learning. Over time, however, and given the hierarchical framing of the image, with the White man clothed in a suit and atop a horse, central to the image, the statue's meaning has changed, leading to the praiseworthy and long-awaited decision to remove it in 2020.

Create Topic Sentences

Use the models below to create your own topic sentences to focus each paragraph on a specific technical or contextual aspect of the image.

- **Pattern.** The sculpture unites the three figures—four, including the horse—primarily through the repetition of musculature, armor, weapons, and costumes.
- **Point of view.** Because the sculpture is large, tall, and set on a pedestal, it requires viewers either to look up at it or to regard it from a distance—both postures requiring a certain degree of reverence.
- **Arrangement.** The sculpture's three human figures are arranged in a triangle, suggesting an apex with two supporting angles.
- **Symbolism.** Each man is dressed in the clothing of his homeland, giving each allegorical significance as racial, rather than individual, representations.

Build Body Paragraphs

Support each topic sentence by describing in detail the elements you have chosen to assess. When describing the image, avoid overuse of adjectives and adverbs. Use concrete rather than abstract nouns. Abstract nouns name ideas, such as *perspective* or *theme*; concrete nouns refer to specific, tangible elements, such as *triangle*, *line*, or *granite*. Incorporate strong verbs as well as the necessary forms of *to be* (*is*, *are*, *was*, *were*). Think about what the features in the image are *doing*—the ways they interact with one another, the space around them, and the viewer's relationship to them. Finally, avoid speculation while going beyond description. Keep the discussion rooted in the evidence, and show readers what the evidence points to, what it means.

Sample Body Paragraph: Arrangement

> The sculpture's three human figures are arranged in a triangle, suggesting an apex with two supporting angles. President Roosevelt is by far the tallest of the three and always visible from whichever angle the viewer faces the sculpture. Meanwhile, the two flanking figures can be seen fully only from the front or the back, suggesting that they lack nuance or subtlety because they can be seen and understood only directly. When seen from an angle, they are either overshadowed by the White man on horseback or disappear from view. Similarly, level with the Native American and the African is the horse, all three depicted with sharply defined muscles, highlighting their strength. Roosevelt is similarly well defined but fully clothed and towering over both the animal and the two men. Overall, the sculpture suggests, at the very least, a hierarchy among the three men and, at worst, a dominance of the White man over those of color.

Formulate a Conclusion

After you have developed the body paragraphs in which you analyze and reflect on the image, conclude by expanding on your thesis and suggesting directions to consider in the future. One important role of the conclusion is to further the discourse by showing how this rhetorical moment is merely one example of other such discourses and how they can be used productively in other contexts. In this case, an effective strategy

would be to outline criteria for memorials of historical figures, even those with complicated legacies and flaws.

Sample Conclusion

> The people concerned with public spaces—city planners, museum curators, and government and other leaders—must determine who is worthy of remembrance and how. In doing so, they need to consider historical, contextual, cultural, and artistic concerns, and they must seek and respond to public input. Now is the time to draft guidelines for these decisions.

Peer Review: Separate the Personal from the Technical

After you have drafted your paper, you are ready to review the work of your peers while they review your work. Keep in mind that you and your peers are almost certainly going to respond to images differently. This is the value of critical discourse about visual rhetoric: pooling shared responses and experiences helps develop a greater understanding of the human condition. As you review your peers' writing, part of your task is to separate your personal responses from the writer's analysis of the image's technical elements.

Here are some topics and questions to get you started on a peer analysis of someone else's work:

- **Consider the context, including culture.** Indicate places where the writer has done well or can supply more information.
  - In what ways has the author included enough information to prepare you for the analysis?
  - What else would you like to know?
  - Is any information superfluous or irrelevant?
  - In what ways has the author addressed cultural issues—their own and those of the intended audience?
  - What else should be considered?
- **Read the first sentence of each paragraph.** Write your answers to these questions.
  - Does a clear outline emerge?
  - What, if any, changes can you suggest to improve the flow?
- **Examine each paragraph.** Highlight places where descriptions or analyses are insufficient, and make suggestions for improvement.
  - In what ways does the paragraph reflect a clear, vivid, and technical description of the image?
  - In what ways does the paragraph move beyond description into analysis to explain the effect of the technical elements?
- **Read the conclusion.** If the author has not outlined strategies for the future or contributed to ongoing discourse, provide your suggestions, or brainstorm some ideas with them.

Revising: Hone Your Practice

Writing the first draft is hard work, and you are right to feel pride and a sense of accomplishment after completing it. Thus, any critique can feel unjust and even personally wounding. Remember, though, that writing is a process and that everyone is an apprentice, working toward expertise and, eventually, mastery. So take every opportunity you can to learn from others and hone your skills.

First, reward yourself for completing the first draft. You may choose to take a long walk, prepare a favorite meal, or enjoy some leisure time with friends. Savor the moment. Time away from the writing process is time for your writing and thinking muscles to recover. Consider some light reading. Think about it this way—you'll never build muscle if you go to the gym all day while you starve yourself. In the same way, you've expended a lot of vocabulary and sentence- structure energy. Feed it to rebuild it.

Finally, return to your work with a goal in mind and a plan to put it into place. Look at the feedback you received. *Does your work require major revision or minor tweaks?* If the latter, then your task is simple: make a

to-do list and get started! If the former, go back to the drawing board and diagnose your own process, considering the following questions:

- Is your current understanding of context, culture, audience, or purpose different from what it was at the outset? If so, what changes do you need to make?
- Are your descriptions insufficient, unclear, or vague? Revisit "Reading" Images and Glance at Genre: Relationship Between Image and Rhetoric and consider the terminology and techniques introduced there in light of your image.
- Is your analysis insufficient or missing? Review Glance at Genre: Relationship Between Image and Rhetoric and the example in Writing Process: Thinking Critically and Writing Persuasively about Images. Reflect on your image and consider your assumptions.
- Do you have a clear introduction, conclusion, and body paragraphs with topic sentences? Is each paragraph fleshed out with meaningful descriptions and analysis?

After you think about these topics and take notes based on your thoughts, you can make a plan and revise your work with confidence.

17.6 Editing Focus: Descriptive Diction

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Apply editing strategies to highlight the features of visual rhetoric.
- Edit to include concrete nouns and descriptive language when writing about images.
- Identify instances of wordiness and overused modifiers and edit to eliminate them.

People reading about visual and digital images expect to encounter vivid, descriptive language that allows them to picture the image as they read. Particularly helpful is detailed language, such as precise names for colors (for example, aqua, teal, or navy for different shades of blue) or similes (for example, *steel blue like the October sky seen through a heavy Los Angeles smog*). This type of language helps readers visualize the image differently and broadens their range of experience. Such descriptive writing incorporates your personal experience with the elements of visual rhetoric discussed in this chapter.

Consider the following suggestions to help you bridge the gap between your experience and that of your reader.

- **First, use concrete, rather than abstract, nouns.** An abstract noun is a word such as *concept* or *practice*. It refers to an idea rather than a thing. A concrete noun refers to something visible or tangible: *arc*, *circle*, or *line*. Your reader can identify concrete nouns in the image and follow your description more meaningfully.

  Example 1

  Original: The artist used a lot of colors for the face instead of dividing it into lights and darks.

  Revision: The French painter Henri Matisse (1869–1954) used blues and greens, along with reds and yellows, to depict the woman's face instead of separating it into realistic color and shading.

  Example 2

  Original: By the placement of the figures, the sculptor depicts dominance.

  Revision: By placing the African and Indigenous figures behind and lower than the central figure mounted on horseback, the sculptor depicts the dominance of the White man, Theodore Roosevelt.

- **Second, use adjectives sparingly.** Readers rely on subjects and verbs to draw meaning from sentences. Those are the words that light up the synapses and neurons in people's brains. They are the characters and actions in stories, while all other words act as "filler." Although they provide color, interest, and detail, they lack the power of subjects and verbs. So let your subjects and verbs pack the punch, and reserve

adjectives and adverbs for special occasions.

Consider the advice given by one of America's classic writers, Mark Twain (1835–1910): "When you catch an adjective, kill it. No, I don't mean utterly, but kill most of them—then the rest will be valuable. They weaken when they are close together. They give strength when they are wide apart. An adjective habit, or a wordy, diffuse, flowery habit, once fastened upon a person, is as hard to get rid of as any other vice."

Example 1

Original: Inside and outside, the big, shiny memorial building was covered with many very small, brightly colored tiles.

Revision: Both the interior and exterior of the memorial were adorned with mosaics.

Example 2

Original: The bleak meadow, which looked very dreary and not very serene, with bits of snow all around, was the perfect backdrop for the majestic eagle and its massive nest.

Revision: The snow dotting the meadow made it look bleak rather than serene, highlighting the majesty of both the eagle and its nest.

- **Finally, strengthen verbs by removing weak, wordy structures.** *There are* and *it is* are two such structures. If you look deeper into the sentence, you usually can find a verb masquerading as a noun. While you're at it, eliminate unnecessary or filler words, such as prepositions or repetitive conjunctions.

  Example 1

  Original: It is obvious that the artist intended that the painting should be something that projects clarity and insight.

  Revision: The artist obviously intended the painting to project clarity and insight.

  Example 2

  Original: Throughout the United States near the end of the landscape painting era, there was growing disillusionment among artists with the naturalness of nature.

  Revision: As the landscape painting era neared an end, U.S. artists became increasingly disillusioned with the naturalness of nature.

Practice Using Descriptive Diction

Revise the following descriptions to eliminate abstract nouns, adjectives, adverbs, and extra words. Be sure to keep the same meaning.

1. The dirty, grimy, broken walls in the artist's painting of the building really show anyone looking at it that there is no one living there because of the condition or maybe some other reason.
2. The drawing is really very beautiful; the artist has done a great job of making the face look like the real person's face, especially the features.
3. In the picture, there are flowers in a vase and some food and other things on a table; in the background, there is a cat.

17.7 Evaluation: Relationship Between Analysis and Image

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Apply or challenge measurement outcomes for written discourse in the field of visual rhetoric.
- Compare your written work with evaluation criteria.

Below are the criteria that your instructor will use to assess your written work for this chapter. As you read them, consider how they align with the elements of visual rhetoric identified and analyzed throughout this chapter. As you plan, write, and revise, consult the following rubric carefully to ensure that you are meeting the critical cultural and rhetorical expectations for assessing images. Consider also ways you might usefully and creatively challenge such expectations—for example, by adopting a unique voice in which to write that rejects language such as "point of view" but still results in an effective piece of persuasive writing.

Rubric

Score	Critical Language Awareness	Clarity and Coherence	Rhetorical Choices
5 Skillful	The text always adheres to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: using descriptive diction, as discussed in Section 17.6, and employing sensory detail. The text also shows ample evidence of the writer's intent to consciously meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The thesis and organization are clear. Paragraphs are evenly and fully developed, with topic sentences. Sentence structure is balanced. The introduction offers a clearly relevant context, and the conclusion is insightful. The writer has used transitions to ensure coherence throughout.	The author demonstrates consistent skill in using the technical language associated with visual rhetoric—line, light, and point of view, for example—and consistently speaks to the reader in an engaging and professional tone.
4 Accomplished	The text usually adheres to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: using descriptive diction, as discussed in Section 17.6, and employing sensory detail. The text also shows some evidence of the writer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The thesis and organization are clear. Paragraphs are evenly and fully developed, with topic sentences. Sentence structure is generally, if not consistently, balanced. The introduction offers a relevant context, and the conclusion is insightful. The writer has used transitions to ensure coherence in most places.	The author demonstrates some mastery of the technical language associated with visual rhetoric—line, light, and point of view, for example—and usually speaks to the reader in an engaging and professional tone.
3 Capable	The text generally adheres to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: using descriptive diction, as discussed in Section 17.6, and employing sensory detail. The text also shows limited evidence of the writer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The thesis and organization are fairly clear. Some paragraphs may lack topic sentences, or topic sentences may be unclear. Some paragraphs may be undeveloped. Sentence structure may be unbalanced. The introduction offers a relevant context, and the conclusion is adequate, if not insightful. Transitions may be missing in key places.	The author demonstrates familiarity with, if not mastery of, the technical language associated with visual rhetoric—line, light, and point of view, for example—and usually speaks to the reader in an engaging and professional tone. There may be occasional lapses in vocabulary, tone, or comprehension.

TABLE 17.4

Score	Critical Language Awareness	Clarity and Coherence	Rhetorical Choices
2 **Developing**	The text occasionally adheres to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: using descriptive diction, as discussed in Section 17.6, and employing sensory detail. The text also shows emerging evidence of the writer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The thesis may be implied rather than stated, and the organization may be unclear. Paragraphs may lack topic sentences and may be undeveloped. Sentence structure is likely to be simplistic. The introduction offers little context, and the conclusion is impractical or simplistic. Few transitions provide minimal, if any, coherence.	The author demonstrates little, if any, familiarity with the technical language associated with visual rhetoric—line, light, and point of view, for example. The tone may be inconsistent and informal or unprofessional at times. There may be occasional lapses in vocabulary and comprehension as well.
1 **Beginning**	The text does not adhere to the "Editing Focus" of this chapter: using descriptive diction, as discussed in Section 17.6, and employing sensory detail. The text also shows little to no evidence of the writer's intent to meet or challenge conventional expectations in rhetorically effective ways.	The thesis is missing or irrelevant to the assignment. Paragraphs are unevenly developed and poorly organized. Sentence structures and word choices may be simplistic or exhibit substantive errors that impede comprehension. The introduction or conclusion may be missing. Alternatively, the introduction provides no context, or the conclusion merely summarizes the paper. Lack of transitions contributes to general incoherence.	The author demonstrates little, if any, familiarity with the technical language associated with visual rhetoric—line, light, and point of view, for example. The tone is inconsistent and often informal or unprofessional. There may be lapses in vocabulary and comprehension as well.

TABLE 17.4

17.8 Spotlight on … Video and Film

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Examine and apply key techniques used in film and movies to personal rhetorical and cultural contexts.
- Implement a variety of technologies to address a range of audiences.
- Create a multimodal work that incorporates visual rhetorical techniques.



FIGURE 17.18 Ken Burns (https://openstax.org/r/Ken-Burns) (b. 1953), American historian and documentarian (Credit: "KenBurns" by Jim Wallace/Wikimedia Commons, CC-BY-2.0)

Lights, Camera Angles, Actions

This chapter focuses largely on still images, but many of the same principles apply to moving images, or film. Documentaries in particular combine a series of still or moving images with historical and narrative text. This section shows how the concepts of visual rhetoric apply to the documentary work of Ken Burns. It also encourages you to examine your experience through such techniques by creating a film autobiography.

The field of movie and film artistry is vast, constituting an entire field of study in its own right. One notable figure in the field is the American history film documentarian Ken Burns (b. 1953), who is responsible for nearly 200 films as writer, director, producer, or all of the above. From *The Civil War* (1990) to *The Vietnam War* (2017), from *Jackie Robinson* (2016) to *Country Music* (2019), Ken Burns has documented the American experience in richer and more layered ways than can be achieved via print text alone.

Burns's style is deceptively simple. His documentaries are narrated in an informative, objective manner, sometimes by a well-known figure in politics, sports, or entertainment whose work is related to the documentary topic. The images consist of archival footage, which differs depending on the topic, ranging from black-and-white photographs to grainy home videos. These are interspersed with interviews from eyewitnesses and experts.

Of the many techniques that Burns employs, three are of particular interest: **foreshadowing**, **the personal vs. the universal**, and **juxtaposition**.

Foreshadowing

Documentaries are not known for being riveting, suspenseful, edge-of-your seat thrillers, but Ken Burns keeps audiences enthralled for hours on end. *The Civil War*, for example, consists of nine episodes totaling 11 hours and 30 minutes. One important way Burns keeps audiences engaged is by implying that things are not as they seem or that a major change is just on the horizon. Such warnings are delivered by his narrators often just after a peak emotional moment either of contentment and resolution or of fear and anxiety. The effect is to

make the audience question what could possibly happen next and to keep them tuned in for the next episode.

The Personal vs. the Universal

History may move in giant sweeps across times and places, but it happens day by day with the mundane choices made by ordinary people. Burns excels at highlighting the small, personal tales of individuals who changed the course of history and the ways massive historical movements affected individual people's lives. The back-and-forth of these forces plays out in his work like a delicate ballet in which the lead dancers move toward and away from one another on stage, amplifying the tension each time.

Juxtaposition

Like any serious historian, Burns is interested not merely in *what* happened but also in *why.* This investigation requires that he go beyond appearances, a challenge for a filmmaker who relies on images to make his meaning clear to viewers. Burns often demonstrates for viewers how people and events converge by showing an ordinary American soldier, farmer, or sports figure, for example, alongside a powerful political figure. Alternatively, he may pan out from a newspaper headline only to zoom in on a story printed deep within the fold. In the viewer's mind, the placement of such figures plants an impression that is immediately upended or replaced. The experience can be jarring, but the technique leads to deep learning and retention, which is one reason Burns's documentaries leave a lasting impression on his audience.

Burns often works in conjunction with the Public Broadcasting Service (PBS), which funds and airs much of his work. To see these techniques in action, visit his page on the PBS website and watch a short clip of his biography of Jack Johnson (https://openstax.org/r/short-clip) (1878–1946), the first Black American heavyweight boxer to became world champion—in the height of the Jim Crow era.

Publish Your Work: Film Autobiography

Make a documentary of your own! Document the process of writing your essay or select a meaningful moment in your life—an event, an anniversary, an accomplishment, a disappointment—and create a 3–5 minute multimodal video about it, incorporating video, still images, and text that explore the significance of the moment in your life. Post your finished product to YouTube. Table 17.5 lists resources you can use to produce and publish your video, including ways to limit viewership and address privacy concerns.

Video Creation Software

Name	Notes	Location
Lightworks	Best for beginners. Includes stock images.	LWKS (https://openstax.org/r/LWKS)
VideoPad	Open access and easy to use. Limited functionality.	VideoPad (https://openstax.org/r/VideoPad)
HitFilm Express	Somewhat advanced. Allows special effects. Must share status update on social media to use.	HitFilm (https://openstax.org/r/HitFilm)
OpenShot	For intermediate users.	OpenShot (https://openstax.org/r/OpenShot)

YouTube Resources

Description	Location

TABLE 17.5 Resources for making a film autobiography

Video Creation Software

Name	Notes	Location
	Upload videos to YouTube privately so that you control who sees them and when.	YouTube (https://openstax.org/r/YouTube)
	Set your YouTube audience to comply with the Children's Online Privacy Protection Act.	Channel Setting (https://openstax.org/r/Channel-Setting)
	Set your YouTube video to be visible only to your professor and classmates.	Sharing With a Specific Audience (https://openstax.org/r/Sharing-With)

TABLE 17.5 Resources for making a film autobiography

A film autobiography about your experiences with writing and images can help you consider the way you use images in discourse. It also serves as good practice in thinking critically about your experiences and their relation to both images and language. Finally, a film autobiography allows you to communicate your experiences and reflections with others, expanding their worldview as well as your own.

17.9 Portfolio: Interplay Between Text and Image

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this section, you will be able to:

- Articulate your use of images in light of their rhetorical context and elements.
- Analyze images rhetorically both in and out of academic settings.

The consideration of visual rhetoric is not merely an academic exercise. Because visual and digital images are ever-present, thinking critically about them is a meaningful way of interacting with the world, reflecting on attitudes and behaviors, and communicating with others. You can apply what you learned in this chapter by considering the images surrounding you: those you see on advertisements in public spaces, those you view on television and other streaming services, and those you see and post on social media platforms.

Interacting with Images Online

As you add your essay to your portfolio, continue conscious and reflective practice in your own writing by thinking about an image you recently posted on one of your social media platforms. Consider the following questions, returning to "Reading" Images as needed.

- Does it contain information open to interpretation?
- What is its point of view?
- How is it arranged?
- What colors or symbols does it use, and what associations might these have for you or others?

Draft an analysis of your own image-posting behavior to include in your course portfolio. The purpose is both to showcase and continue practicing the writing skills and techniques you learned from this chapter and to assess and reflect upon the ways in which you interact with visual and digital images. Remember to include the following elements in your analysis:

- **Introduction.** Establish the context. Material here should include relevant information about you, your posting platforms and behaviors, and the image you posted. Should you choose to write a persuasive piece, your introduction should include a thesis statement identifying your position and one or more reasons for it.
- **Paragraphs with clear topic sentences.** Focus each paragraph on a technical element of the image, and ensure that it contains a mixture of description and either reflection, analysis, or persuasion. Begin each

paragraph with a topic sentence identifying the paragraph's focus.

- **Image(s).** Because you are describing and assessing the image you posted, a copy of it will go a long way toward helping your audience understand it. If the image is in the public domain, embed it with a citation. If not, embed a link so viewers can see it on the Internet.
- **Citations.** Understanding context often requires research. Furthermore, images have creators who deserve recognition for their work. Follow MLA guidelines to cite all of your sources, including the image.
- **Conclusion.** Go beyond summarizing to identify future image-posting practices that you intend to consider and would encourage others to consider.

In conclusion, this chapter explains the concepts associated with both visual rhetoric and writing about visual and digital images. Through the numerous examples, analyses, and procedures outlined here, you can connect your personal and cultural experiences to the visual and digital images with which you interact. In doing so, you can make meaningful connections with a variety of audiences, permitting a broader understanding of the world and its many visual depictions.

Further Reading

The following is a list of some texts and museums that can help deepen your understanding of visual rhetoric.

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El Museo del Barrio. New York, NY, www.elmuseo.org/

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Honeywill, Paul. *Visual Language for the World Wide Web*. Intellect, 1999.

The Honolulu Museum of Art. Honolulu, HI, honolulumuseum.org/

Jenks, Chris, editor. *Visual Culture*. Routledge, 1995.

Los Angeles County Museum of Art. Los Angeles, CA, www.lacma.org/

McClean, Shilo T. *Digital Storytelling: The Narrative Power of Visual Effects in Film*. MIT P, 2007.

National Memorial for Peace and Justice. Montgomery, AL, museumandmemorial.eji.org/memorial

National Museum of Mexican Art. Chicago, IL, nationalmuseumofmexicanart.org/

O'Connell, Mark, and Raje Airey. *The Illustrated Dictionary of Signs and Symbols*. Anness, 2009.

Perelman, Chaïm, and Lucie Olbrechts-Tyteca. *The New Rhetoric: A Treatise on Argumentation*. Translated by John Wilkinson and Purcell Weaver, U of Notre Dame P, 1969.

The Rubin Museum of Art. New York, NY, rubinmuseum.org/

The Smithsonian National Museum Network. Washington, DC (collections with special cultural interests detailed below)

Asian Pacific American Center, smithsonianapa.org/

Latino Center, latino.si.edu/latino-center

National Museum of African American History and Culture, nmaahc.si.edu/

National Museum of the American Indian, americanindian.si.edu/

Freer Gallery of Art and Arthur M. Sackler Gallery, the Smithsonian's National Museum of Asian Art, asia.si.edu/

Stocchetti, Matteo, and Karin Kukkonen, editors. *Images in Use: Towards the Critical Analysis of Visual Communication*. John Benjamins, 2011.

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Whitney Plantation. Wallace, LA, www.whitneyplantation.org/

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